

PHISHING EMAIL ANALYSIS

1. INTRODUCTION

Phishing is a common social engineering attack where attackers use fake emails or messages to trick users into revealing sensitive information, clicking malicious links, downloading harmful files, or making unauthorized payments.

Phishing emails often imitate trusted organizations such as banks, companies, educational institutions, or online services.

2. OBJECTIVE

The main objective is to develop the ability to identify phishing emails and recognize suspicious indicators.

Specific Objectives

- Identify suspicious sender addresses.
 - Analyze links and attachments.
 - Recognize urgency and threatening language.
 - Identify requests for sensitive information.
 - Learn how to safely respond to phishing emails.
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3. COMMON PHISHING INDICATORS

1. Suspicious Sender Address

Check whether the sender's email address and domain actually belong to the claimed organization.

2. Suspicious Links

Check the destination of links before clicking. Misspelled domains, shortened URLs, and unrelated websites can be warning signs.

3. Urgency and Threats

Attackers often use messages such as:

- "Your account will be suspended."
- "Immediate action required."
- "Verify your account within 24 hours."

4. Suspicious Attachments

Unexpected attachments may contain malware. Do not open attachments unless the sender and file are verified.

5. Requests for Sensitive Information

Be suspicious of emails requesting:

- Passwords
- OTPs
- Banking information
- Personal information
- Login credentials

6. Spelling and Formatting

Poor grammar, unusual formatting, and spelling mistakes can indicate phishing, although professional-looking emails can also be fraudulent.

4. PHISHING EMAIL ANALYSIS CHECKLIST

Before interacting with an email, check:

- Is the sender known?
- Does the email address match the organization?
- Is the request expected?
- Does the email create urgency or fear?
- Are there suspicious links?
- Are there unexpected attachments?
- Is sensitive information being requested?
- Can the request be independently verified?

5. SAMPLE PHISHING EMAIL

From: security-alert@secure-account-login.com

Subject: URGENT: Your Account Will Be Suspended

Message:

"Dear Customer,

We detected unusual activity on your account. Your account will be suspended unless you verify your identity.

Click the link below to confirm your account."

Analysis

This email contains several phishing indicators:

- Suspicious sender domain
- Generic greeting
- Urgent language
- Threat of account suspension
- Suspicious verification link
- Possible request for sensitive information

Conclusion: The email should be treated as suspicious and independently verified before taking any action.

6. HOW TO RESPOND TO PHISHING

If a phishing email is suspected:

1. Do not click any links.
 2. Do not open unexpected attachments.
 3. Do not reply to the email.
 4. Do not share passwords or OTPs.
 5. Verify the message through an official channel.
 6. Report the email to the IT/security team.
 7. If credentials were entered, change the password immediately and report the incident.
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7. PHISHING PREVENTION

- Check the sender's complete email address.
- Avoid suspicious links and attachments.
- Use MFA for important accounts.
- Access websites directly instead of using links in suspicious emails.
- Keep systems and browsers updated.

- Participate in cybersecurity awareness training.
 - Report suspicious emails.
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8. PHISHING VS LEGITIMATE EMAIL

Feature	Legitimate Email	Phishing Email
Sender	Verified	Suspicious or impersonated
Links	Expected and relevant	Misleading or suspicious
Language	Normal	Often urgent or threatening
Attachments	Expected	Often unexpected
Information	Normal request	May request sensitive data
Verification	Can be confirmed	Often discourages verification

9. CONCLUSION

Phishing emails are a major cybersecurity threat that exploit human trust to steal information or compromise systems. By carefully checking sender addresses, links, attachments, urgency, and information requests, users can identify many phishing attempts.

The safest approach is to STOP, CHECK, VERIFY, and REPORT before taking action on suspicious emails.